

Composer Study





About the Course

In this course students are immersed into the 19th century via its composers, instruments, and musical performances. Term 1 focuses on several influential instruments/instrument families, including valved brass, the veena, and the guitar, and the musicians that made them famous. In Term 2, students will grow to know and love the Norwegian Romantic composer, Edvard Grieg. Students conclude the year in Term 3 with the comic operas of Gilbert & Sullivan and their choice between two composers who turned what they saw or heard into music: Modest Mussorgsky and Thomas ("Blind Tom") Wiggins.

This topic is included in the following course(s): Music: Level 1, Music: Level 2, Music: Level 3, Music: Level 4, Music: Level 5

Composer Study

"Music is no isolated thing. Its forms, colors, and expressive qualities do not spring from nowhere; they come out of life itself. Often, of course, they are to be enjoyed for themselves alone, in the concert hall or in one's armchair. But music also reflects human experiences, hopes, and struggles. It may give an insight into the individual and society, into the lives of those far removed from our own in time and place—an insight no other art can provide in this exact way."
~Elie Siegmeister



Placement & Combining Tips

These Composer Study lessons are shared across grades 2-12 with extensions provided for older students. Students in Grades 2-3 with no classical music background may choose to take Intro to Music Appreciation first, but the composers in this rotation are particularly accessible for a wide range of ages.



Scheduling

GRADE	SCHEDULE INFO.	BOOKS
2-12	Composer Study 1 time/week 10 min 1 time/week 15 min	Playlist for the Year Mussorgsky's Pictures at an Exhibition Song in a Rainstorm: The Story of Musical Prodigy Thomas Blind Tom Wiggins

Sample Weekly View

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5
Music: Level 1				
Sol-fa: Level 1	Hymns & Spirituals Afternoon Listening		Folk Songs	Composer Study
Music: Level 2				
Sol-fa: Level 2	Hymns & Spirituals	Folk Songs	Composer Study Afternoon Listening	
Music: Level 3				
Sol-fa: Level 3 Afternoon Listening		Hymns & Spirituals	Folk Songs	Composer Study

Music: Level 4				
Sol-fa: Level 4 Afternoon Listening		Hymns & Spirituals	Folk Songs	Composer Study
Music: Level 5				
Sol-fa: Level 5 Afternoon Listening	Hymns & Spirituals	Folk Songs	Composer Study	



Planning & Prep

Permission to print for non-commercial use. See Alveary group use policy to use lessons in a group context.

LINKS: Click text or scan the QR code in the top corner of the lesson plan pages to view online resources associated with the lessons.

Responsibility for previewing all links rests with the teacher. All links were checked at the time of publication; however, websites change frequently and may contain objectionable content. Please report broken links by contacting us through our website.

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- Charlotte Mason often included more music in the program than could be covered in the lesson time. While we choose segments that fit the length of the lesson, students will develop a relationship with the term's music insofar as it is a part of their daily atmosphere.
- The YouTube playlist contains nearly the whole year's music, though lessons will occasionally have extra links to historical or musical information. Feel free to create your own playlist if you prefer other platforms to YouTube; though videos are often chosen for visual and sometimes historical interest, the crucial element is the music itself.
- Use the year's playlist to listen to previous and current pieces in the afternoons, and explore the Extra Helpings as interested (ideas which relate directly to a lesson are usually included nearby, while more general resources and activities are listed on the Extra Helpings page). Grade 5+ extensions are also usually appropriate as Extra Helpings for interested younger students.

Term Prep & Teacher Tips

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☐ Lessons on Handel's Messiah are scheduled at the beginning of Term 2, so many students will reach them around the Christmas holidays. However, depending on how you schedule your year, this may not fit. Feel free to complete the lessons whenever suits your schedule. The Messiah is as much (or more) an Easter piece as a Christmas one, so you could even bump it to Term 3!



Books & Resources

For book rationales and purchase options, click the Book List link or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Book List Details](#)

Composer Study



Our Work: Grades 1-2



Our Work: Grade 3



Our Work: Grades 4-6



Our Work: Grades 7-8



Our Work: Grades 9-12



Hymns, Spirituals, & Folk Songs PDF



Playlist for the Year



Mussorgsky's Pictures at an Exhibition



Song in a Rainstorm: The Story of Musical Prodigy Thomas Blind Tom Wiggins



Supplies

For supply list details and basic supplies helpful to have on hand, click the links or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Basic Supplies](#)

(No Subject Supplies Assigned)



Quick Links

Composer Study

- ∞ [Extra Resource: Classics for Kids Musical Dictionary](#)
- ∞ [Composer Study Playlist](#)
- ∞ [Appendix: Musical Vocabulary](#)

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or scan the QR
code for links.



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How To Teach



Recap

- Specific recap questions are often suggested in the day's plans; ask students what they remember from the last lesson. If nothing comes to mind at first, tell them to give themselves another minute or two and to keep thinking. Our brains are amazing and can usually recall the previous lesson with a minute of effort. Refrain from doing the work of remembering yourself if you are leading the lessons.
- For composer study, a recap might look like a brief discussion about the name or sound of the piece you listened to previously.
- For hymns and folk songs, this might be an effort to hum the melody or recite the words of the song you're currently learning.
- For sol-fa, it might be a quick explanation of the sol-fa syllable you learned or a tricky rhythm or interval you were working to master.
- If students have difficulty recalling, teachers might try showing them a picture or sharing something that the teacher remembers. This will often refresh their memory enough to allow them to recall.
- If students still cannot recall anything from the last reading, then teachers may consider continuing anyway or repeating the last lesson.



Introduce

- Prepare to listen to the day's musical selection by inviting students to consider an interesting musical or historical idea in the lesson. Perhaps it's a unique word, rhythm, instrument, or piece of historical background. You might introduce it by the way, or read a selection of a composer's bio or a brief article to students.



Listen & Sing

- Listen to the day's musical selection.
- Composer study lessons will usually have you listen to a piece of music for 3-8 minutes. If students have a difficult time listening for the duration of the lesson, stop the music at their limit.
- Some students might draw, color, or engage in a handicraft while listening to help extend their listening time. Students who have a difficult time sitting still or listening may benefit from: a fidget of their choice, such as a piece of putty or clay or an afghan; flexible positioning, such as a wobble seat or inverted sitting; or sensory modulation, such as a weighted vest or blanket or adjustment of light, temperature, or sound.
- Hymn, folk song, or sol-fa lessons will sometimes have you listen to a part of the song and then practice echoing back the melody and/or words.



Discuss

- **Composer Study:** Talk about the musical selection you heard. What stood out to you? What did you notice? What did it make you wonder? Did it remind you of anything? Discuss the tempo, the sound of the music, the instruments used, the volume, and the mood. Why do you think the composer wrote it the way he did?
- **Hymns, Spirituals, & Folk Songs:** What lines strike you particularly? Is there a rhyme scheme to the lyrics? Is there a progression to each stanza? If you were to add a verse to the song, what would you add? If you took a verse out, how do you think it would change the song? Do the melody and words go together? Why or why not?
- **Sol-fa:** Take a minute to reflect on what you learned in the lesson. Write down any notes you want to remember and practice any particular exercises that were tricky.



Connect

- At the end of the lesson, think about how the day's musical selection connects to other books, subjects, characters in history, etc.
- You might copy down a stanza of a hymn in your Commonplace or Copywork book, read a bit more about the history behind a piece of music, jot down a noteworthy date in your Book of Centuries, or discuss a broader question raised in the lesson.

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Term 1	
WEEK 1	15m Composer Study - Lesson 1
WEEK 2	15m Composer Study - Lesson 2
WEEK 3	15m Composer Study - Lesson 3
WEEK 4	15m Composer Study - Lesson 4
WEEK 5	15m Composer Study - Lesson 5
WEEK 6	15m Composer Study - Lesson 6
WEEK 7	15m Composer Study - Lesson 7
WEEK 8	15m Composer Study - Lesson 8
WEEK 9	15m Composer Study - Lesson 9
WEEK 10	15m Composer Study - Lesson 10
WEEK 11	15m Composer Study - Lesson 11
WEEK 12	15m Composer Study - Lesson 12

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Term 2	
WEEK 1	15m Composer Study - Lesson 13
WEEK 2	15m Composer Study - Lesson 14
WEEK 3	15m Composer Study - Lesson 15
WEEK 4	15m Composer Study - Lesson 16
WEEK 5	15m Composer Study - Lesson 17
WEEK 6	15m Composer Study - Lesson 18
WEEK 7	15m Composer Study - Lesson 19
WEEK 8	15m Composer Study - Lesson 20
WEEK 9	15m Composer Study - Lesson 21
WEEK 10	15m Composer Study - Lesson 22
WEEK 11	15m Composer Study - Lesson 23
WEEK 12	15m Composer Study - Lesson 24

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Term 3	
WEEK 1	15m Composer Study - Lesson 25
WEEK 2	15m Composer Study - Lesson 26
WEEK 3	15m Composer Study - Lesson 27
WEEK 4	15m Composer Study - Lesson 28
WEEK 5	15m Composer Study - Lesson 29
WEEK 6	15m Composer Study - Lesson 30
WEEK 7	15m Composer Study - Lesson 31
WEEK 8	15m Composer Study - Lesson 32
WEEK 9	15m Composer Study - Lesson 33
WEEK 10	15m Composer Study - Lesson 34
WEEK 11	15m Composer Study - Lesson 35
WEEK 12	15m Composer Study - Lesson 36